

test drive ■ undercover

Dare to go lower

Agent 001 sets out in search of the cheapest deal on PCs

People are always talking about how to build the most powerful PC, but what about those on a shoestring budget? Wait! Make that a single-fibre-of-a-shoestring budget! What is the absolutely cheapest functional machine that you could possibly put together? Forget about shattering fps records in *Quake III*, or working on massive image files. If 99 per cent of your daily applications revolve around word processing and the Internet then you're in for a surprise.

Gone are the days when the lowest entry-level computer meant shelling out Rs 30,000. Hardware costs have plummeted, much to our delight. Follow me as I mosey over to the friendly neighbourhood hardwarewallas and find out what system components can be scrounged together to help us build the cheapest possible computer but still has more than adequate processing power, decent storage and memory. And remember, all these are brand new components!

The October heat can be really sweltering and no matter where you are shopping, remember to pack a cap—hardware shopping could sap you out (and no, the cost of the cap is not included in the system)! Since my finances did not allow a cross-country travel allowance, I headed for Lamington Road, the first, last and final frontier for hardware shopping in Mumbai.

My quest had me traverse six dealers over 3 hours in the post-monsoon morning sun. Eager dealers tried to push a whole assortment of goodies down my throat—all the way from Duron, to Celeron and P-III

processors, bundled with the usual range of peripherals. At each estab-

needs. Next up, I settled for a stick of PC133 RAM. There a brands to choose from and if you particular about names such as or Crucial, you can buy it for Rs 1,200.

For the motherboard, I didn't from the trusty Intel 810E as from HIS. The board came with ed graphics and sound (so I don't spend any extra there picked it up for Rs 2,850. For the hard disk, I decided on a Seagate U8 40 GB (5,400-rpm) for about Rs 4,150.

In the next might, I could not find a new drive I needed 40 GB. Well, it was so good. I went to my shopping for a little 10,000 baht. For the monitor, I found one against every consideration a monitor; after budget mongers had

a standard! The cheapest I could find was from Micron at Rs 4,700 and this suited my needs fine. For the cabinet, I settled on a Baby AT box at Rs 850—no shiny colours here. The only CD-ROM drive available at a low price range was 52x drives and I chose one from Krypton that cost me Rs 1,150. My Vesta 104 key keyboard and three-button serial mouse cost Rs 300 and respectively. I finally sealed the deal with a pair of simple stereo speakers costing Rs 350, and a trusty modem from Lancer for Rs 450. I finally add Rs 500 for the monitor (though I doubt if I'll ever use 1.44 MB Sony floppy drive).

All done! I've got the build for a fully functional Office 2000/Internet surfing computer complete with a 500 MHz processor, RAM, a 40 GB hard disk, and a Modem 8.2 (courtesy of the Digit June 2002) for a shade under Rs 20,000!

In the end, it took repeated efforts to drive home the point that I was on an absolute rundown budget and wanted the cheapest hardware. Finally, after much probing into their inventory, it paid off and I came across some very interesting options, at

the most amazing prices!

First up, the core system components: the processor, motherboard, RAM and hard disk. I found that the most inexpensive processor is the 500 MHz Cyrix MIII available for a cool Rs 2,100! While this processor wasn't made to shatter any speed records, it definitely suited my humble, everyday

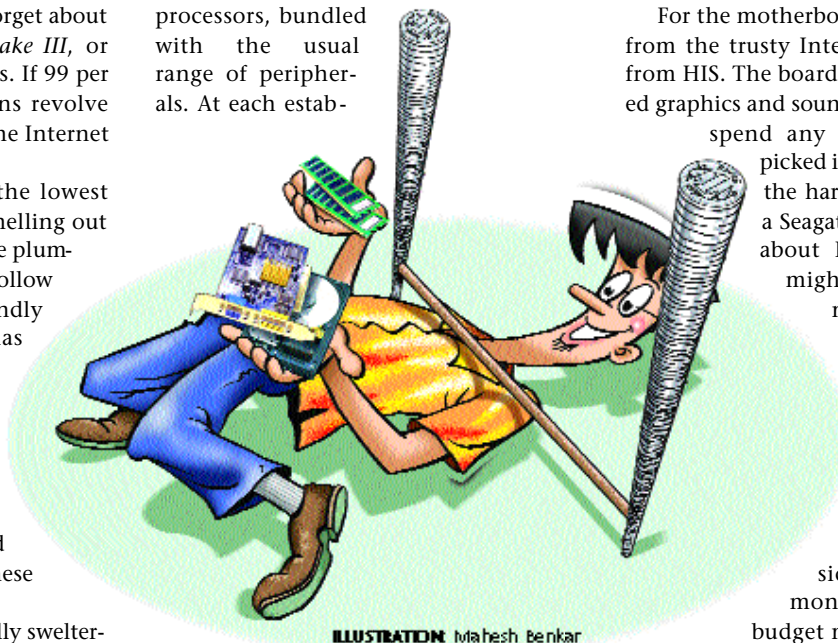


ILLUSTRATION Mahesh Benkar

The Shopping List

Component	Brand	Price (Rs)
Processor	Cyrix MIII 500 MHz	2,100
Motherboard	HIS 810E	2,850
RAM	Generic PC133 128 MB	1,200
Hard disk	Seagate U8 40 GB (5,400-rpm)	4,150
Cabinet	Generic Baby AT	850
Keyboard	Vesta 104	300
Mouse	Mercury 3-button scroll	150
Monitor	15-inch Microtek	4,700
Speakers	Generic stereo speakers	350
CD-ROM drive	52x Krypton	1,150
Modem	Lancer 56K PCI	450
Floppy drive	Sony 1.44 MB	500

Note: The prices could vary over time and geographical locations. Please use them as a guideline and not as a thumb rule.